

#Design System Chat

GDS

HELLO!

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📹 This session will be recorded

Please turn your camera off if you don’t wish to appear in the footage.

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This is a monthly chat about design systems, hosted by the GOV.UK Design System team.

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This is a safe space. Please be kind.
Feel free to speak openly.

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Meeting hygiene:

Please stay on mute 🔇 unless talking.
Use the hands up button ✋ if you want to come in.

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It’s still nice to have feedback, so feel free to react via the reactions icon.



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#DSChat

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Today’s agenda

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Service Patterns

- What is a service pattern?
- Show & tell: Service Patterns mini-discovery
- Are you working on anything pattern related?

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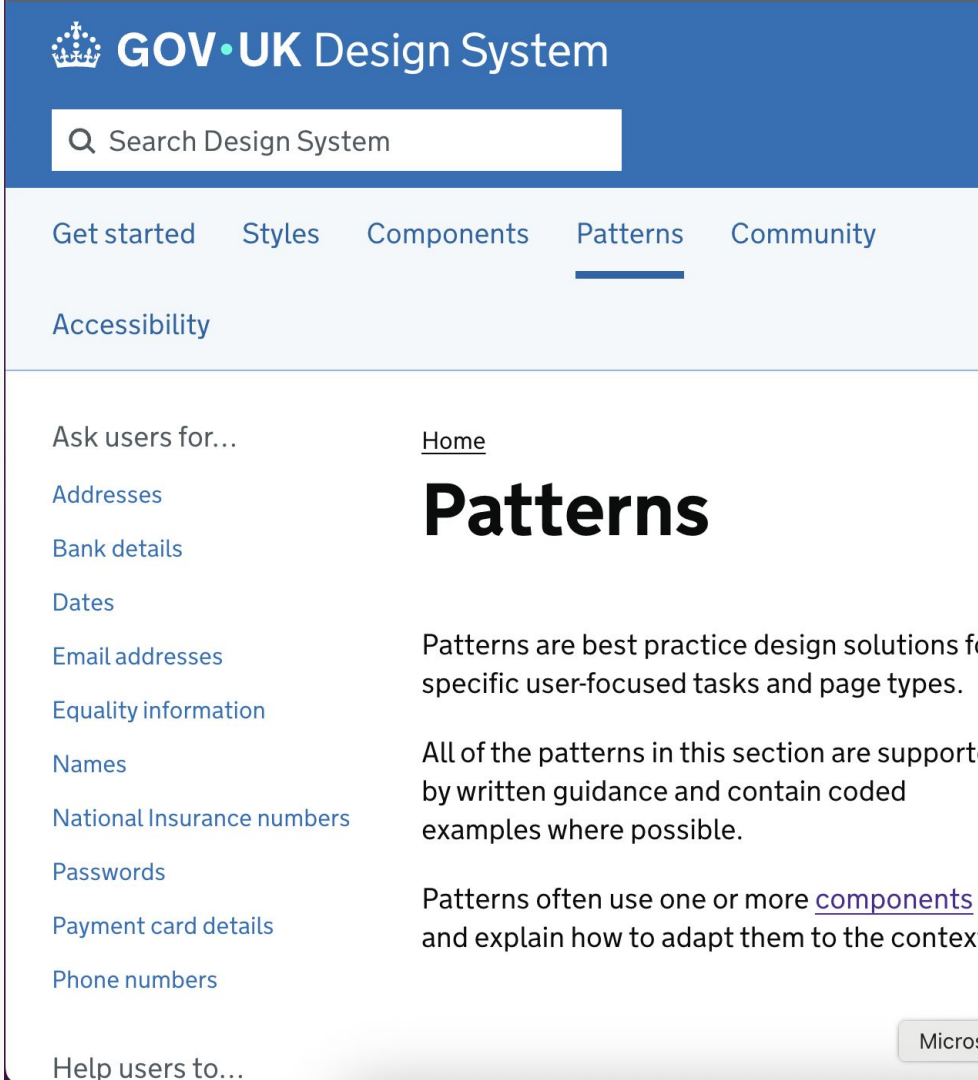
What is a Service Pattern?

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We have patterns on the GOV UK Design System but they don’t sit at a service level

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What is your understanding of service patterns?

What other terms have you heard?

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Padlet

imranhussaingds • 8m

Service Patterns - |#DesignSystemChat September 2025

What is your understanding of Service Patterns?

What other terms have you heard?

Are you working on anything pattern related?

Add section



Discussion:

What is your understanding of service patterns?

What other terms have you heard?

Groups (15 mins)

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Feed back

(5 mins)

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Patterns - discovery, Sept 2025

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What were we looking to discover?

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What do people understand of the terms reusable pattern and service pattern?

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There were 14 user interviews - so far



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We dug into:

- What is a service pattern?
- What is a reusable pattern?
- Do you use any similar terms?
- What pattern libraries do you use?
- Are you working on patterns at the moment?

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Reusable patterns

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The term reusable patterns isn’t really used by designers.

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P10: If it’s not reusable, it’s not a pattern.

P9: I don’t think I’ve consciously heard it. Every pattern is reusable right?

P5: Reusable patterns is a generic term. The patterns I use are either UI patterns or service patterns.

However, people think that service patterns would count as a type of reusable pattern.

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P2: Reusable is a thing that can be picked up and used in multiple spaces, and I think a service pattern is reusable.

P4: Service patterns are reusable, but reusable patterns are not necessarily service patterns.

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Service patterns

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People’s knowledge of service patterns was based on whether they had directly worked on service patterns or not.

P9: My understanding is from other people presenting their work. If you click through to a service, there are certain aspects that can be repeated, like booking a service.

P6: To me, when you're doing an end to end service journey - when you’re applying for something or actually doing something at GDS. In a wider context, completing the journey.

P2: We defined it as an organisation. Reusable and replicable parts of services. Common building blocks (steps, stages tasks) of end-to-end services.

P7: Structured way of describing reusable user tasks that can be combined to build or shape end-to-end services.

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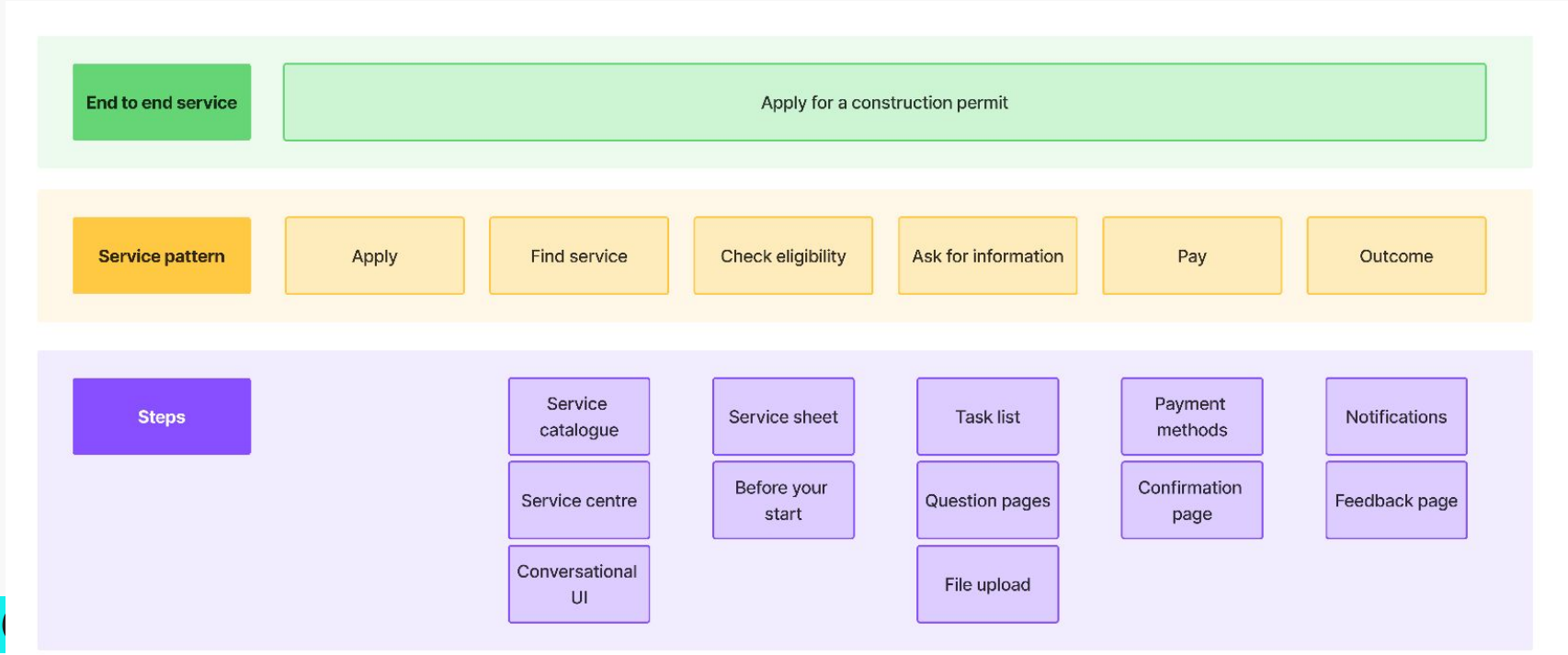
There was no consensus on a definition of the term service pattern.

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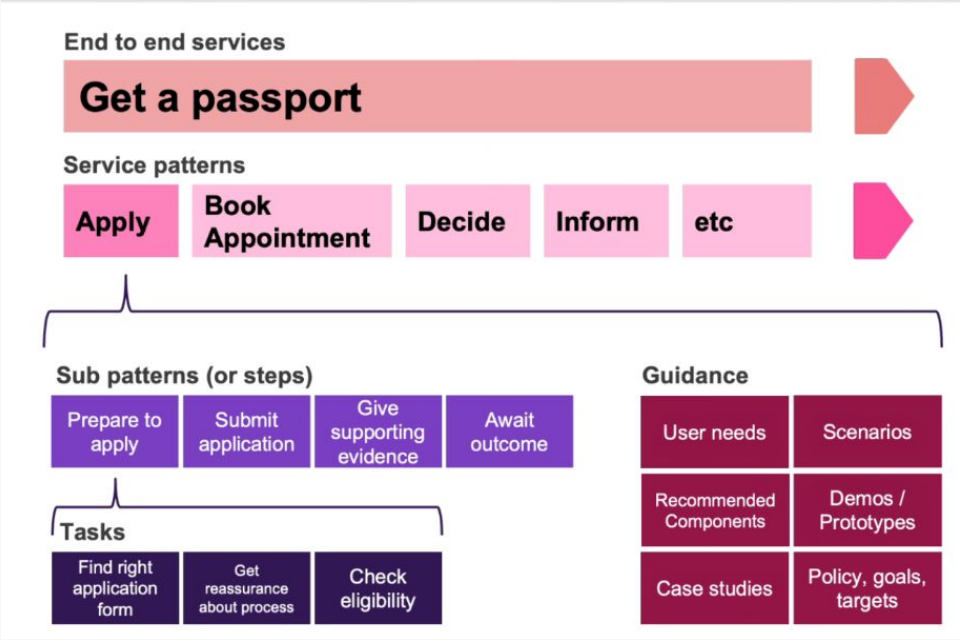
P5: Yes. It’s really hard to put in words. Common user flows between multiple user journeys, or multiple services for instance. You are thinking about the multiple users and the multiple actions they will take. The multiple user flows will be chunked and turn into a service pattern.

Those who had developed service patterns themselves were able to articulate the different layers that service patterns are broken down into.

P1: A pattern is the map of how you put the steps together. Patterns can be made of flows and have certain steps.

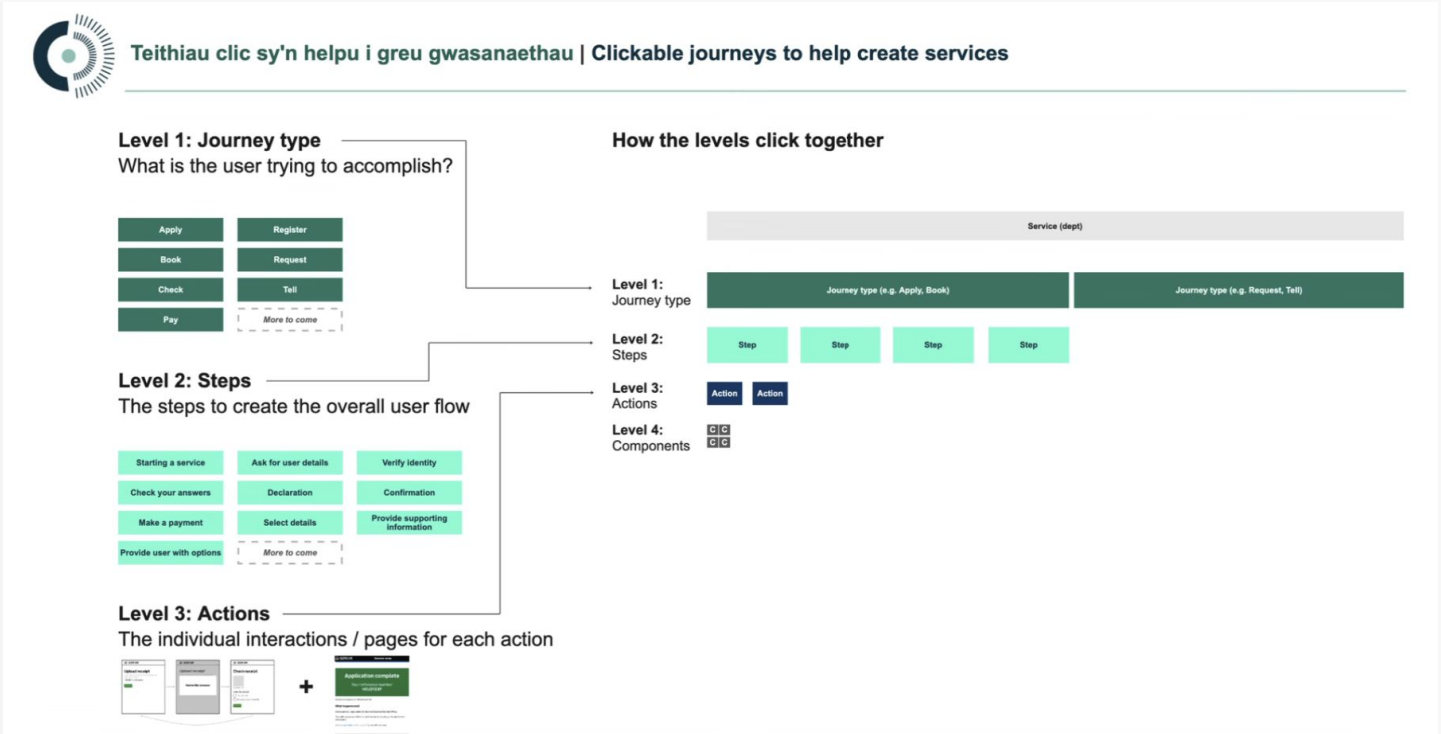


P7: a service pattern is broken down to sub patterns (P7 prefers ‘Steps’) and Tasks.



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P12: Yep it works at different levels.We’re working on a digital journey: register, request, tell, check, pay. The journey is made up of steps.



These layers, levels, or steps are highly context-dependent. They vary by the context an organisation is working in.

Identified service patterns

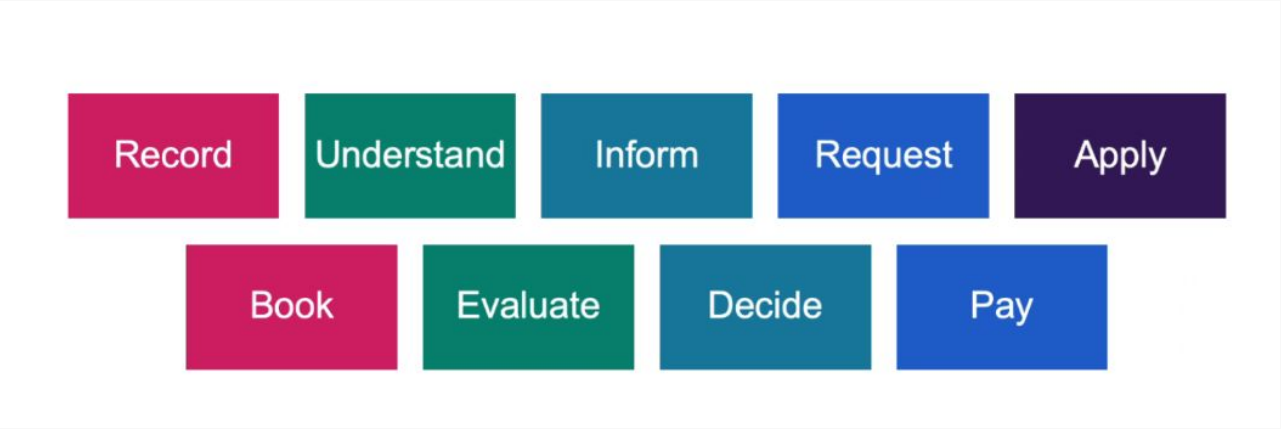
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Some organisations are way ahead and have started to identify common service patterns.

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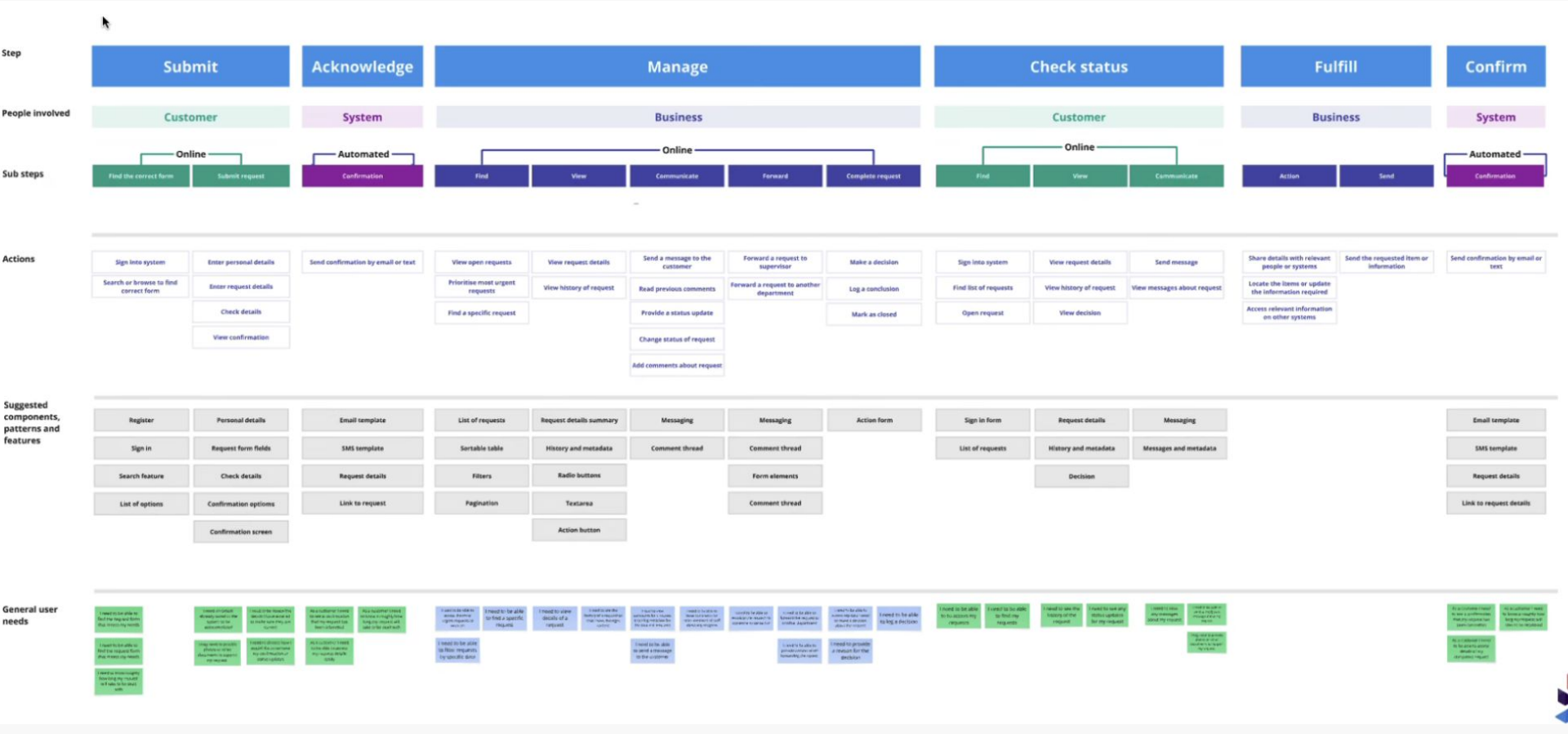
Within government, there is no consensus on what the common patterns are, or what they are called (yet).

Ministry of Justice

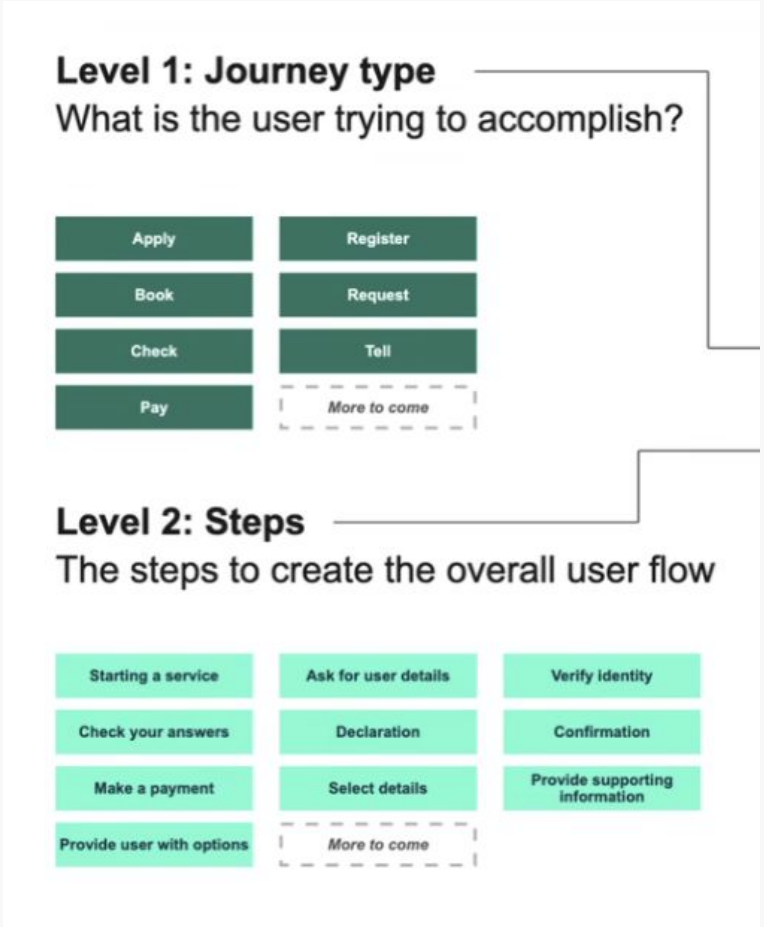


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DWP


Step
Submit
Acknowledge
Manage
Check status
Fulfill
Confirm
People involved
Customer
System
Business
Customer
Business
System
Sub steps
Online
Find the correct form
Submit request
Automated
Confirmation
Online
Find
View
Communicate
Forward
Complete request
Online
Find
View
Communicate
Action
Send
Automated
Confirmation
Actions
Sign into system
Search or browse to find correct form
Enter personal details
Enter request details
Check details
View confirmation
Send confirmation by email or text
View open requests
Prioritise most urgent requests
Find a specific request
View request details
View history of request
Send a message to the customer
Read previous comments
Provide a status update
Change status of request
Add comments about request
Forward a request to supervisor
Forward a request to another department
Make a decision
Log a conclusion
Mark as closed
Sign into system
Find list of requests
Open request
View request details
View history of request
View decision
Send message
View messages about request
Share details with relevant people or systems
Locate the items or update the information required
Access relevant information on other systems
Send the requested item or information
Send confirmation by email or text
Suggested components, patterns and features
Register
Sign in
Search feature
List of options
Personal details
Request form fields
Check details
Confirmation options
Confirmation screen
Email template
SMS template
Request details
Link to request
List of requests
Sortable table
Filters
Pagination
Request details summary
History and metadata
Radio buttons
Textarea
Action button
Messaging
Comment thread
Messaging
Comment thread
Form elements
Comment thread
Action form
Sign in form
List of requests
Request details
History and metadata
Decision
Messaging
Messages and metadata
Email template
SMS template
Request details
Link to request details
General user needs

CDPS (Wales)



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TPX Impact are developing their own patterns based on their client work

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TPX Impact



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Work in progress

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There is a cross-Gov group that is trying to collaborate on service patterns.

P8: We’re doing experiments with ‘Apply’ across several departments to some degree. There’s a X-Gov Slack channel.

DWP started with a list of user needs which other departments added to, to derive a common list of user needs. We’re also looking at sub patterns, but we don’t have screens or visuals yet.

UK Government D...

Home
DMs
Activity
Files
Later
More

↑ More unreads

maps_
software-development
xgov-software-community-orga...

Channels

accessibility
admin-interfaces
announcements
ask-heads-of-content
chat
content
events
future-of-slack
gds-engagement
govuk-prototype-kit
green-software-development
hiring
hmrc-design
homeofficedigital
inclusivity
jewishnetwork
lgbt
liberatingstructures
moj-design-system
muslimsingov
neurodiversity
oneteamgov
proj-slack-champions
service-patterns
servicedesign

↓ Unread mentions

service-patterns

147

Messages | Files

Thursday, July 24th

❤️ 9 👏 2

Friday, July 25th

Ibiyemi Driver [Defra] 2:51 PM
joined #service-patterns. Also, Rob Davies_DVSA and 12 others joined.

Tuesday, September 16th

Martin Ford-Downes (MOJ) 3:14 PM
ImranHussain_GDS
Hello design friends, the next **Design System Chat** is at **2pm-3pm BST** on **Tuesday 30 September**.
This month, we'll be discussing **Service Patterns**:

- Have you heard of Service Patterns? What does the term mean to you?
- Show & tell: Service Patterns mini-discovery - Imran Hussain, GDS

Show more

Posted in # servicedesign | Sep 16th | View message

👍 1

Message #service-patterns

Andrew Knight has convened several people from the International Design in Gov community to work on service patterns.

These groups have formed sub-groups around work areas: education, healthcare, welfare, policing etc.

REC

The Welfare Working Group

Ireland: DPER - Department of Public expenditure, Infrastructure, Public Service Reform and Digitalisation

Finland: *KELA* Kansaneläkelaitos (The Social Insurance Institution)



Peru: *National Council for the Integration of People with Disabilities*

UK: DWP - *Department for Work and Pensions*



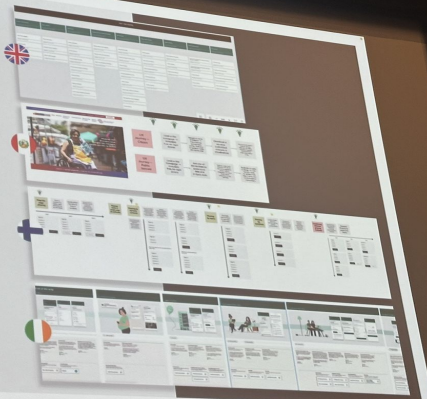
Working Group

Anna – UI Designer
Janne – Lead Designer
Päivi – Service Designer
Anni Human Centred Designer
Trevor – Policy Design Lead
Lindsay – Lead Service Designer
Alice – Head of Service Design
Shalom – Lead Designer
Kieran – Senior Service Designer
Stuart – Strategy, Policy & Delivery
Gian – Specialist in Evidence Generation
Mauricio – Specialist in Monitoring & Evaluation
Nayeli - Project Manager

RCA's screen

What we Shared

- Service patterns from UK
- National Disability Observatory evidence site from Peru
- Phasing form patterns from Finland – Kela's design system
- (later, during workshop 2) *'Having a baby'* life event journey from Ireland



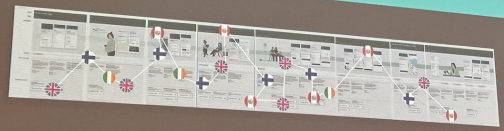
screen

REC

What we Tried to do

After sharing our work, we started on the mini-conference design exercises together.

1. Voted on patterns which were common for our countries / orgs
2. Short-listed three potential patterns to elaborate on together
3. Identified the features of three common patterns
4. Tried to start breaking down the value of each feature
5. **Realised we needed to try a different approach!**
6. Walked through life event journey and mapped other patterns



RCA's screen

Defining Pattern Attributes

- Instead of asking ***what*** *patterns do we each have?*, we asked ***what makes*** *something a pattern?*
- Shifted the conversation from outputs to **underlying qualities**, and to attributes that work across all scales - from components up to life events.
- Defining these attributes gave us shared ground to talk across different levels of maturity, scale and approach.

Attributes of a Global Pattern

Repeatable Consistently applicable across different contexts

User-focused Centred on solving real problems for people

Actionable clear enough to be applied & adapted in real work.

Proven Backed by evidence and demonstrated in practice.

Trust Building Creates confidence and legitimacy for users and the public

RCA's screen

TPX Impact are running workshops and are trying to work in the open on their service pattern library.

They have run internal workshops, hosted online sessions, and run workshops at conferences.

SDinGov

Tickets Keynotes Programme Pre-event party Sponsors Location Contact Videos Archive

Pattern spotting workshop

Session type:
Workshop

Presented by:
Jaskiran kang
TPXimpact

Tash Willcocks
TPXimpact

Ibarieze Abani
TPXimpact

Session time:
17 Sep 14:15 — 16:15
Session duration:
120 minutes

About the session

Theme: Patterns

We're seeing huge overlaps across services and organisations. There's a need to define the standards of good practice so it becomes easier to apply repeatable patterns.

More now than ever, cross department join ups are needed. Patterns can create more consistent, efficient, and user centred services.

Through working in a consultancy environment with many talented designers and client sectors, the speakers have been able to spot the patterns from a holistic perspective.

The talented service designers at TPXImpact created a workshop structure to help designers get to grips with pattern spotting inside services. The organisation now runs a 1-day in person masterclass with its client teams.

Jas and Tash will give a taster of this masterclass

About the speaker(s)

Jaskiran kang

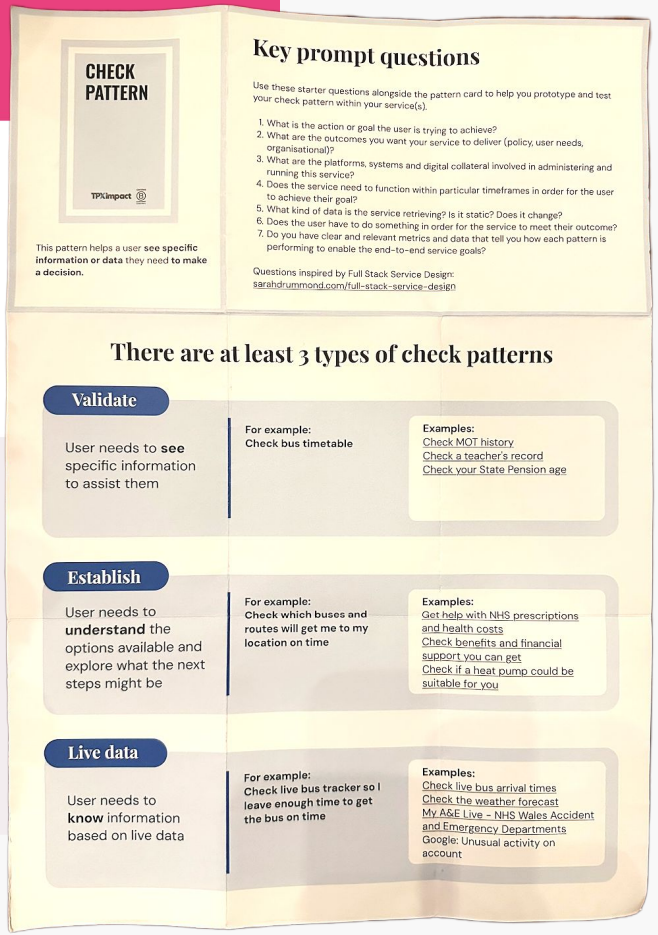
Jas is a designer! She enjoys problem solving.

She is Head of Service and Organisation Design at TPXImpact. She consults in digital transformation for public sector, local gov and third sector clients.

Jas has transitioned into design leadership for the last 4-5 years and has been working in design for the last 18 years. She's been experimenting with a range of leadership techniques to build a thriving practice and designers.

More recently, through working in a consultancy environment with so many talented designers and clients, it's been a super power to see the patterns from the holistic perspective.

Where each department is constrained within the box they belong in,



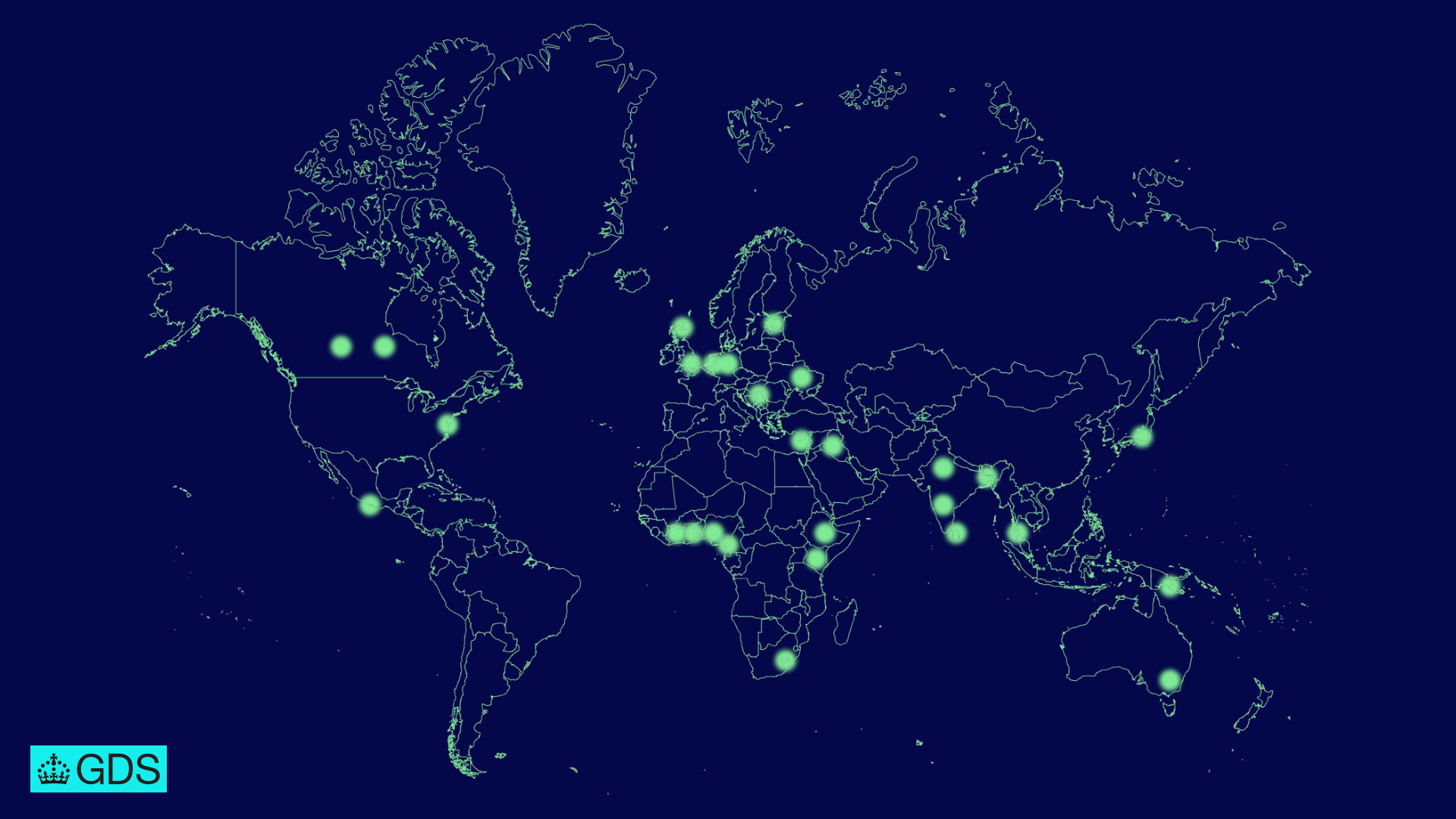
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GovStack are working on a pattern library that works across services internationally.

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They have a working group from across the world using real-life examples to help build service patterns.

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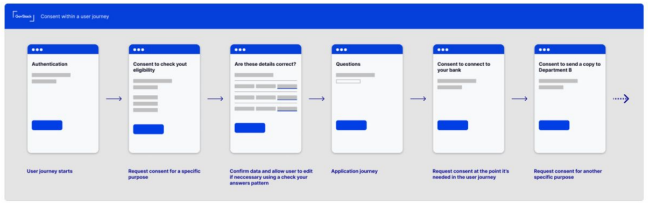

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GovStack 23Q4 Give Feedback GovStack Home Search

GovStack
Contributing
Architecture and Nonfunctional Requirements
Security Requirements
GovStack UI/UX Guidelines
1 Version History
2 Description
3 Service design good practice guidelines
3.1 User-centred design
3.2 Accessibility and inclusion
3.3 Consistency
3.4 Technology choices
4 Design patterns
4.1 Service patterns
4.2 User flows
4.2.1 Register
4.2.2 Authenticate
4.2.3 Asking users for feedback
4.2.4 Find a service
4.2.5 Check a users eligibility
4.2.6 Make an application
4.3 Page templates
4.3.1 Feedback
4.3.2 Perception survey
4.3.3 Satisfaction
4.3.4 Before you start
4.3.5 Service sheet
4.3.6 Asking users for consent
4.3.7 Task list
4.3.8 Asking users for information
4.3.9 Check answers
4.3.10 Outcome
Powered by GitBook

4.3.6 Asking users for consent

Use these patterns to give users control over how you manage their data. These patterns align with the GovStack Consent Building Block.



*Note that images can be expanded by clicking on them.

Related Building Block: GovStack Consent Building Block.

How it works

Consent covers all activities done for the same reason. If you use the data for more than one reason, get separate consent for each. For example, accessing data to check eligibility is separate from accessing data to make an application.

Use these patterns when you need to:

- To access a user's data.
- To store, manage or share a user's data.
- Allow users to manage the data you hold on them.

When not to use these patterns

You do not need to ask for consent when:

- the data is required for a government to perform a specific task or function set out in law, you do not need to ask for consent. For example, terms and conditions — these are required so you do not need to ask for consent.
- a person is simply informed of the processing of the data by the organisation as part of the service provided under contract or by an authority.
- consent does not have to be obtained in a situation where the entity does not identify or cannot identify people with reasonable effort.

How it works
When not to use these patterns
Consent page
Why we ask to share this data
About the data
Confirm or reject
Implied consent
Handling data beyond the transaction
Managing consent
Delegated consent
Additional details for information collection
Was this helpful?
Export as PDF

Give Feedback GovStack Home Search

single data sets
Consent
of consent for a single data set

Consent for multiple data sets
Why we need it and user benefit
How it will be used and for how long
What is the data
Checkbox for each dataset
How to manage or revoke access
Consent
A wireframe of consent for multiple data sets

How it works
When not to use these patterns
Consent page
Why we ask to share this data
About the data
Confirm or reject
Implied consent
Handling data beyond the transaction
Managing consent
Delegated consent
Additional details for information collection
Was this helpful?
Export as PDF

implementation
Consent - Example implementation

users for consent
4.3.7 Task list
4.3.8 Asking users for information
4.3.9 Check answers
4.3.10 Outcome
Powered by GitBook

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Other related terms

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When talking about service patterns, designers referred to user flows or user journeys.

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P11: When we first started, we called SP repeatable user flows. We focus on online journeys, online service patterns. Users flows, journeys
Originally we called them phases or stages - but we felt journey type was a lot more plain language.

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Lego, building blocks, and templates were also used to refer to reusable parts of services.

P1: Probably something as simple as templates.

P2: Systems thinking, journey mapping are also very important in this. Design system, library, full-stack service design.

P3: Building blocks is a term that works well.

P5: Internally, we talk about Lego blocks. But we’re trying to avoid that term publicly.

There’s some tension with design system language.

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P7: It’s a shame, almost, that the term design system is out there. It would be perfect for this.

P10: Did a lot of work on a full-stack design system at DWP. We thought about multiple layers, frontend, backend, technical.

P3: Patterns, this can become muddled because it’s in Design Systems, what we refer to as 'sub patterns'.

Challenges

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What level does it need to be pitched at?

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P7: There are questions about how useful service patterns are. It needs to be quite generic to fit every service. Is it better than starting from scratch? Cross gov is still working out what the next steps are. Not sure about viability and feasibility.

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It will require a rebalancing of other layers to be cohesive and make sense.

P4: Service Patterns have no home yet. We struggle with this. Could be in the DS? Could be in the Service Manual?

P7: Design system don’t directly line-up with Service patterns. You can’t just say, this is the service pattern, use this design system component when it comes to building it.

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P12: I’m not sure you can have a consensus anyway. We were mostly trying to talk about levels and fidelity of services, how zoomed in or out do you need to be. A pattern for a bit of a service map.

Service patterns will probably need clear guidance and training

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P3: We see using Service Patterns as at a ‘hand holding’ stage at the moment, it’s very low-fi

P12: Need to think about how it will work. Is it an async product? Or a series of workshops where we teach orgs to patternise their work?

Still not lift and shift, all hypotheses need validating with user research.

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P4: The aim is to enable people people to focus on the unique parts of their service and repeat the things that we know about already.

P8: We still need design and research. This just allows us to start several steps ahead.

Areas of potential

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Going beyond design into tech architecture and data sharing

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P2: We’re looking at the back-end processes. The actual value is so that data passes between organisations.

P10: We connected Service Patterns to technical patterns. So that they don't have to build things from scratch. Technical pattern, what components, how they will connect, what data will flow throughout.

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There’s a lot of work going on. In fact, it’s been happening for a while.

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FUTUREGOV

Department for Environment Food & Rural Affairs

GovStack

TPXimpact

Canolfan Gwasanaethau Cyhoeddus Digidol
Centre for Digital Public Services

DWP Digital

gov.scot

Ministry of Justice

INTERNATIONAL DESIGN IN GOVERNMENT

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People are very keen to collaborate, share work, and input.

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Summary

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#1] Service patterns is a hard to define term. It is not consistent.

#2] Service Patterns vary by the context they are being used or created in.

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#3] There’s lots of work happening that we can tap into.

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Are you working on anything pattern related?

It doesn’t have to be service patterns

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Discuss in groups

[15 mins]

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Feed back

[5 mins]

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Padlet

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What is your understanding of Service Patterns?

What other terms have you heard?

Are you working on anything pattern related?

Add section



Next session:
October

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Thank you



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See you next time! 👋

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